Lesson 33 material: Pronunciation: Thought Groups

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 4: Education and Creativity

4.5: Thought Groups

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Original page, with audio and online exercises:
https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Book%3A_Speaking_Listening_and_Pronunciation_Projects_for_ELLs_-_Intermediate_Level_(Zemlick)/04%3A_Education_and_Creativity/4.05%3A_Thought_Groups
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Audio for this section is saved on your computer in `E:\personal-tutor\materials\library\esl-b1-speaking\attachments\04.05-thought-groups`: Thought Groups Warm Up

Thought Groups

English speakers divide language into phrases called "thought groups."

Warm Up

Listen to the speaker read the sentences in two different ways. Which one is easier to understand? (Audio on the lesson web page: "Thought Groups Warm Up")

1. While I love learning English, I don't have time to do the homework, and taking tests makes me nervous.
2. While I love learning English, /I don't have time to do the homework,/ and taking tests makes me nervous.

Which words are stressed in sentence 2? Underline them. Why are they stressed?

Rules to Remember

Rules to Remember: Thought Groups

1. Thought groups usually have one focus word.
2. The focus word (the word with the strongest stress/ most importance) is often at the end of the thought group.
3. The intonation usually goes up on the focus word and then down at the end of each thought group.
4. Thought groups are usually followed by a brief pause.

Watch the Video

Pausing within Sentences - Elemental English

Video: https://youtu.be/YyY63ivixOs

Practice: 25 Things to do in Berlin

1. Listen to the recording and read the transcript. Work with a partner to draw a line each time the speaker pauses.
2. Check and compare your answers with the class.
3. Which words are stressed in each thought group? Underline them and compare with a friend. Did you underline the same words?

Video: https://youtu.be/Iw5NHQeXzpA

Transcript

(00:00-00:33)

We had heard Berlin was a city bursting with art and music and we were very excited to spend some time there. Here is our list of the 25 best things to do in Berlin.

The East Side Gallery is the longest remaining strip of the former dividing wall between East and West Berlin. Today the 1.3 kilometer long wall stands as a memorial to freedom and it is covered in art and graffiti.

Practice: Andy's Job

1. Listen to the recording and read the transcript. Work with a partner to draw a line each time the speaker pauses.
2. Check and compare your answers with the class.
3. Which words are stressed in each thought group? Underline them and compare with a friend. Did you underline the same words?

Video: https://youtu.be/Wa0582oOYgY

Transcript

(1:06-2:39)

A: On a day to day basis, I work outside on the farming plots in the South Bay area doing basic farming tasks like planting crops, watering, weeding, harvesting crops, and fence repair.

B: And what do you like about your job?

A: I like most of all, working outside in a beautiful environment and taking lots of fresh air and also doing a job that is in line with my values.

B: Tell me a little more about that. What are your values and how does that align with your job?

A: So my job is specifically looking at sustainable agriculture. And it's a demonstration project to teach other farmers how to use more sustainable growing practices. And one of my fundamental values is that we should be trying to practice farming in an environmentally responsible way, that is sustainable, so that future generations can continue to use the land productively.

Practice: Zero Waste Toothpaste

1. Listen to the recording and read the transcript. Work with a partner to draw a line each time the speaker pauses.
2. Check and compare your answers with the class.
3. Which words are stressed in each thought group? Underline them and compare with a friend. Did you underline the same words?

Video: https://youtu.be/DIpTXQl7qT0

Transcript

(00:00-00:22)

Hey everybody, this is Lauren from Trash is for Tossers and today I'm going to show you how to make Zero Waste Toothpaste! I absolutely love this recipe. It's a great alternative to buying toothpaste in tubes that are either difficult or impossible to recycle. It also works extremely well! I've been using it for years and I still have almost all my teeth!

Practice: TED Talk - Do Schools Kill Creativity?

1. Listen to the recording and read the transcript. Work with a partner to draw a line each time the speaker pauses.
2. Check and compare your answers with the class.
3. Which words are stressed in each thought group? Underline them and compare with a friend. Did you underline the same words?

https://www.ted.com/talks/sir_ken_ro...ill_creativity

Transcript

(15:19-15:43)

Gillian and I had lunch one day. I said, "How did you get to be a dancer?" It was interesting. When she was at school, she was really hopeless. And the school, in the '30s, wrote to her parents and said, "We think Gillian has a learning disorder." She couldn't concentrate; she was fidgeting. I think now they'd say she had ADHD. Wouldn't you? But this was the 1930s, and ADHD hadn't been invented at this point. It wasn't an available condition. People weren't aware they could have that.

Recording: Thought Groups

Read the paragraph from Sir Ken Robinson's TED Talk: Do schools kill creativity? Listen to the video again.

1. Write a "/" when he pauses and underline the stressed word in each thought group.
2. Then practice reading the paragraph out loud.
3. When you're ready, make a video of yourself reading the paragraph. Remember to pause in the correct place and emphasize the most important word one each thought group.

https://www.ted.com/talks/sir_ken_robinson_do_schools_kill_creativity

Transcript

(15:19-15:43)

Gillian and I had lunch one day. I said, "How did you get to be a dancer?" It was interesting. When she was at school, she was really hopeless. And the school, in the '30s, wrote to her parents and said, "We think Gillian has a learning disorder." She couldn't concentrate; she was fidgeting. I think now they'd say she had ADHD. Wouldn't you? But this was the 1930s, and ADHD hadn't been invented at this point. It wasn't an available condition. People weren't aware they could have that.

Links on the original page

- TED talk: https://www.ted.com/talks/sir_ken_robinson_do_schools_kill_creativity